

Session 18: The Shrewd Talking Snake

Key Takeaways

- The snake is described using the Hebrew word *arum*, which means “prudent, cunning, or sensible.” The description isn’t a negative one, and the word does not necessarily indicate trickery or falsehood.
- Given the ambiguous, even positive, introduction of the snake, many have interpreted Genesis 3 as showing the snake’s initial rebellion in conjunction with the humans’ failure.

The Snake and the Woman: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 2:25-3:7

Naked and Unashamed

2:25 And the **two** of them were **naked (ערום)**, the human and his **woman**, and they were not **ashamed**.

3:1a Now the snake was more **shrewd (ערום)** than any beast of the field which Yahweh God had made.

The Dialogue

The Snake

- a 3:1b **And it [the snake] said to the woman** ,
b "Indeed, **has God said** ,
c 'You **shall not eat** from any **tree of the garden** '?"

The Woman

- a 2 **and the woman said to the snake** ,
b " **From the fruit** of the **trees of the garden** **we may eat** ;
3 but **from the fruit** of **the tree** which is in the middle **of the garden** ,
God has said ,
c 'You **shall not eat** from it or touch it, or **you will die** .'"

The Snake

- a 4 **and the snake said to the woman** ,
" **You surely will not die** !
b 5 For **God knows**
c that in the day **you eat** from it **your eyes will be opened** ,

and you will be like **elohim**, **knowers of good and bad**."

The Act

- a 6 and the woman saw that **the tree** **was good** **for eating** ,
- b and that it was desirable to **the eyes** ,
and that the tree was desirable **to make one wise** ,
- c and **she took** from its fruit and **she ate** ;
- c' and **she gave** also to her husband with her, and **he ate** .
- b' 7a **and the eyes of both of them were opened** ,

Naked and Ashamed

- 7b and **they knew** that they were **naked** (ערום);
- a' and they sewed **leaves of a fig tree** together and made themselves loin coverings.

Genesis 2:25-3:7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

Naked and Unashamed and Shrewd

This potent narrative detail is offered to describe the new ideal state of the human creature, who is now a unified plurality. Nakedness in the biblical world refers to a state of ultimate vulnerability. To be naked outside of the garden ideal is to be exposed to the leering eyes of untrustworthy people and is associated with humiliation and shame (see [Isa. 20:2-4](#); [Hos. 2:5](#); [Amos 2:16](#)). To be naked and unashamed is an image of pure trust, openness, vulnerability, and safety.

"Naked and unashamed" is a kind of commentary on "the two become one flesh." When one is truly unified with another, there is no need for self-protection or projection of a false self.

Notice the wordplay between human nakedness (Heb. *arom*) and the snake's "shrewdness" (Heb. *arum*). It is precisely this characteristic of the snake that will transform the humans' nakedness from vulnerability into shame.

A Shrewd, Talking Snake

The character of the snake is a rich and dense narrative image with many layers of meaning. In [Genesis 3:1](#), the snake is described as "shrewd" or "crafty." This Hebrew word, *arum* (ערום), is morally neutral, as it can describe the righteous and wise, like in the book of Proverbs.

Proverbs 22:3 NASB

The *arum* sees the evil and hides himself, but the naive go on, and are punished for it.

Proverbs 12:16 NIV

Fools show their annoyance at once, but the *arum* overlook an insult.

Proverbs 14:15 NASB

The naive believes everything, but the *arum* considers his steps.

Proverbs 8:5 NIV

You who are simple, gain *ormah*; you who are foolish, set your hearts on it.

When the word is used of people with questionable character, the nuance of “crafty” is evident.

Psalms 83:2-3 NIV

² See how your enemies growl,
how your foes rear their heads.

³ With *ormah* they conspire against your people;
they plot against those you cherish.

Job 5:12-13 NIV

¹² He thwarts the plans of the *arum*,
so that their hands achieve no success.

¹³ He catches the wise in their *ormah*,
and the schemes of the wily are swept away.

“[The ‘*arum*’] conceal what they feel and what they know (Prov. 12:16, 23). They esteem knowledge and plan how to use it in achieving their objectives (Prov. 13:16; 14:8, 18); they do not believe everything that they hear (Prov. 14:15); and they know how to avoid trouble and punishment (Prov. 22:3; 27:12). In sum, they are shrewd and calculating, willing to bend and torture the limits of acceptable behavior but not to cross the line into illegalities. They may be unpleasant and purposely misleading in speech but are not out-and-out liars (Josh. 9:4; 1 Sam. 23:22). They know how to read people and situations and how to turn their readings to advantage. A keen wit and a rapier tongue are their tools.”

Zevit, Ziony (2013). *What Really Happened in the Garden of Eden?*. Yale University Press.

Notice also the wordplay between the snake’s introduction and its final destiny in 3:14.

Genesis 3:1 NIV

And the snake was shrewd (ערום) more than every animal of the field (מכל חית השדה) ...

Genesis 3:14 NIV

You are cursed (ארור) more than every beast and every animal of the field (מכל חית השדה) ...

The shrewdness of the snake is a portrait of a creature endowed with the blessing of wisdom who abuses that power for selfish ends.

“Although it is assumed by all the English translations that ערום has a negative sense (‘crafty’) in Genesis 3:1, a closer examination suggests otherwise. The description of the serpent commences with its being ‘more prudent (*arum*) than all the creatures of the field’ (Genesis 3:1), and after having tempted Eve, concludes with its being ‘more cursed (*arur*) than all the creatures of the field (3:14). The two lines are nearly identical in

Hebrew, suggesting an intentional contrast between them: the cursed serpent is a negative contrast to an initially positive shrewd serpent. Not only does 'prudent' make more sense of the narrative flow of events, it also distances God from any responsibility with respect to the origin of evil. God did not make a 'crafty' creature; he made a wise creature. The serpent's 'prudence' may even be a sign of God's special favor toward the serpent above the other animals. The serpent's decision to use its prudence for evil intentions, however, resulted in a fall from divine favor to eternal humiliation, and this offers a solution to the age-old question of the serpent's (and Satan's) fall. When did the serpent rebel and fall? It 'fell' in Genesis 3. Thus, Genesis 3 depicts the fall of Adam, and Eve, and the serpent."

Postell, Seth (2011). [*Adam as Israel: Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Torah and Tanakh*](#). Pickwick Publications.

Reflection Question

Genesis 3:1 tells us that "the snake is more shrewd than any beast of the field." Does this shrewdness imply that the snake is evil?